Claw & Sorcery

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/76348271.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Lyra (Defiance) & Caspin (Raised in Halfmoon), Cyrus (Defiance) & Caspin (Raised in Halfmoon)

Characters:
Lyra (Defiance), Cyrus (Defiance), Caspin (Raised in Halfmoon), Original Female Character(s)

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Training, Magic, Worldbuilding, Halfmoon (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Martial Arts, Light Angst, fic of a fic, Recursive Fanfiction

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Part 13 of Defiance - Raised in Halfmoon AU

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Claw & Sorcery

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

Faced with his fear over recent events, Caspin begs Lyra and Cyrus to let them train in sorcery and martial arts so that they'll be ready for the next time trouble comes knocking.

Should be read after the first chapter of *Heroes of Halfmoon*.

Notes

Yes, that's right, this AU now has side stories. We have officially gone completely insane.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Caspin's Room

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Five Days After Adora's Abduction

Caspin paced in their room, their claws sheathing and unsheathing as his fingers flexed uselessly. He was supposed to be working on an assignment from Cloudfoot—a short essay on the recent history of House Dr'iluth—but they just couldn't sit still, couldn't focus. While this wasn't the first time that Caspin had some trouble focusing, the reason was different from what it usually was.

Caspin was afraid and he needed to *do* something about it.

For their entire short life, Caspin had been plagued by extreme violence. He was born when he was due to the first coup attempt, Big Sis Catra nearly died saving them from an assassin (he hadn't been to a park since), and then there was the second coup attempt that saw everyone except Papa really hurt and Big Sis 'Dora taken away.

Now, Caspin didn't blame themself for the coup attempts or 'Dora getting kidnapped—that'd be more than a little silly even for his young brain—but he *did* blame himself for the incident at the park. After all, Catra and 'Dora had intended to go shopping at the Waxing Market until they had barged in wanting to go play at a park. What's more, the assassin had been targeting *them.* If he hadn't been there, the assassin would have probably tried to go for Catra from the start and Catra wouldn't have gotten stabbed like that.

What's more, as he currently was, Caspin couldn't really defend themself in the slightest. Sure, they could claw and bite with the best of them but that was it. Caspin *needed* to change that in case something bad happened again in the future (and he was reasonably certain that something bad *would* happen again).

Which meant that they needed to convince their parents to let him start training now. He knew that 'Dora started training when she was about two years younger than they currently were so it was only fair, right? They were the princeps, they should be able to defend themself.

That left Caspin was a certain question: should they work on their sorcery first or physical abilities? There was merit to both but Caspin recalled the story of how Catra had taken down the Baron using a series of explosions and how she was losing before then. If it was Catra's magic that had saved the day then Caspin figured that he should start with that.

With their mind made up, Caspin left their room and sought out his mama.

Lyra's Office

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Five Days After Adora's Abduction

"Mama, I want to learn how to use magic," Caspin said without preamble once he was ushered inside by Kittrina. Ever since the second coup attempt, Kittrina followed them around almost everywhere once she had recovered enough to return to duty.

Lyra looked up from her paperwork and blinked a few times in surprise before asking, “What brought this on?”

Caspin fidgeted slightly as he grabbed his tail to stop it from lashing. “I-I want to be strong like you and Papa and big sis and—and—” They couldn’t bring themself to say Adora’s name. “I want to be strong like you guys. I’ve been getting better with my own magic but I wanna be a sorcerer.”

Lyra leaned back in her chair, her hands folded over her stomach as she sighed through her nose and considered her child for a long moment. Caspin fidgeted more and more and was considering saying something else when Lyra finally said, “Very well. You certainly have the magical energy for it and you’re about the age where you should start learning how to harness it anyway. We’ll start your lessons tomorrow, alright?”

Caspin smiled at his mama as they nodded repeatedly. “Yeah, that’s fine!” They then ran around Lyra’s desk and practically threw himself at her to hug her. “Thank you, Mama!”

Lyra chuckled as she smiled down at her youngest child and pet his red mane as she hugged them close. “You’re quite welcome.”

The Training Grounds

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Three Weeks After Adora’s Abduction

Caspin growled in frustration as he swung his mace a few more times, their papa casually deflecting each blow. It had been a bit harder to convince him to let them start training than it had

been for Lyra but all Caspin had to do was bring up how Adora had started even earlier and that had done it.

The reason for Caspin's frustrations had nothing to do with their lack of ability to get a hit in—their papa was *amazing,* after all. Rather, it was because of the weapon itself. After getting some of the basics down with standing, walking, and breathing, they had tried various weapons to find the one right for him but none of them had *clicked.*

"You okay there?" Cyrus asked as Caspin stepped away rather than continue the forms.

Caspin shook their head as they glared at the training mace in their hand. "I don't like it," he said simply.

Cyrus hummed a bit before saying, "Yeah, I kinda figured that the mace wouldn't be right for you. Those things rely on a lot of brute force which just doesn't seem to be your style. Any idea for what you'd like to try next? Or maybe try something again?"

Caspin thought about it for a long moment as he returned the mace to the stand. He's tried swords of all kinds, knives, staves, and now the mace but none of them really let him move the way he wanted to. The closest he had gotten was with knives and daggers but it wasn't quite right.

After a few moments, Caspin extended the claws on their right hand and stared at them before asking, "Can I learn hand-to-hand and how to fight with my claws?"

Cyrus' ears perked up with interest. "I was going to teach you those things anyway since it's a good fallback in case you're ever unarmed. Are you sure you want to focus on them, though? They're largely useless against a heavily armored foe."

"No, they're not. Not for me, anyway," Caspin contradicted. "I can already make my claws, hands, and feet has tough as indorium with my magic."

Caspin's innate magic was the ability to imbue objects with aspects of his choice—Lyra called it a form of transmutation. There currently didn't seem to be a theoretical limit to it but the effects were strongest and lasted the longest if applied either to himself or something that they were holding.

"Really, now? You must've been hard at work with your mama." Cyrus gestured to a nearby training dummy with his head. "Why don't you show me? Cut that with your claws."

Caspin nodded and walked up to the training dummy. With barely a thought, the claws on their right hand gained a slightly metallic sheen to them before he lashed out with a short yell. His tail swayed happily as he watched his claws cleave through it like it wasn't even there.

"See?" he said with a smile that highlighted his cat features as they turned to face Cyrus.

Cyrus looked *very* excited by this. "Ooooo. What else can you do?"

Caspin held out their hand and first ignited their claws with orange flame before letting it spread to cover his entire hand. He then dismissed the flames and let lightning crackle in its place before finally dismissing that, sheathing his claws, closing his hand into a first, and covering it in a thick layer of jagged ice. Each shift took less than a second.

"Oh, you are *good* with that," Cyrus praised as he put away his training sword. "How long does it last?" he asked.

"Pretty much as long as I want," Caspin answered with a proud smirk.

"You are going to be an absolute *menace* on the battlefield if you ever find yourself there and it's going to be *amazing,"* Cyrus said as he returned to Caspin's side. "Alright. Let's begin with some stances and simple punches. Copy me."

The Training Grounds

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Three Weeks After Adora's Abduction

Caspin was breathing heavily by the time Cyrus brought their training session to an end. They immediately dropped out of their stance and placed his hands on his knees as he struggled to catch his breath. His entire body was varying levels of sore and his fingertips as well as the tips of their toes ached from where they had clawed through the training dummy so many times.

Said training dummy was now completely in tatters with bits of it singed from both fire and lightning running through it.

"Very good, very good," Cyrus praised as he curiously examined what was left of the training dummy. "How did that feel compared to the weapons?" he asked.

It took Caspin a while to catch their breath before they could answer. "It felt… pretty good. I could… move the way that I wanted… and attack the way I wanted." He gave his papa a thankful smile as they took the offered canteen of water before greedily drinking from it.

"That's great!" Cyrus said with a smile that was equal parts proud and excited. "I'll admit that I'm not the best at hand-to-hand combat but I'll teach you everything I know and then find someone who can teach you more. How's that sound?"

Caspin nodded vigorously. "That sounds great! I'm gonna be the best hand-to-hand fighter in all of Halfmoon!"

Cyrus laughed. “I believe it! Now, I don’t know about you but all of this training has made me hungry. C’mon, bud, let’s go get lunch.”

Lyra’s Workshop

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Year After Adora’s Abduction

The flickering of enchanted candles and steady light of warning spell circles and runes cast Lyra’s workshop in an almost otherworldly glow. The workshop of a sorcerer was a place that was heavily warded against magic where they could safely practice and study spellcraft. It was a place that could almost be considered sacred to them and this fact was no different for the Queen of Halfmoon.

Bookshelves full of tomes and scrolls written in both Etherian and *Aiilayra* on the subject of spellcraft lined one of the walls, some slightly dusty from disuse while others had some pages creased from earmarks due to frequent consultation.

Along the back wall was a table with a carefully enchanted pot —almost like a cauldron—sitting over a device that could produce a precisely controlled flame used for alchemy. Shelves full of alchemy reagents flanked the desk.

Next to the wall opposite of the bookshelves was a desk upon which was carved a complex magic circle used to aid in the enchantment of items. Above the desk was a floating shelf upon which were several more books on the subject.

In the center of the room was a particularly large spell circle surrounded by a runic array. Its purpose was multitudinous as it served as the primary ward against spell damage but also functioned as an anchor point for the nearest ley line. It drew power from it both to keep that various abjuration spells functional and to make it that much easier to tap into the ley line's power for the purpose of spellcasting. It was near the center of that spell circle where Caspin and Lyra stood, the former's eyes closed in concentration while the latter watched on with keen focus.

Caspin's breath was steady and controlled as they felt their magic flow through them. Words of arcane power were carefully intoned, each syllable striking the air as though they had weight. In front of Capin's outstretched hand, a pale blue spell circle and runic array flared into life.

Three words then five then seven were spoken, each one meticulously practiced to get the pronunciation and cadence perfect. It was the most powerful spell that Caspin had cast to date and his final test before moving on to more advanced spellcraft.

When the spell was complete, Caspin released the magic and smiled as they watched a raging tempest surround their target. Razor sharp blades of wind cut into the conjured target—a simple red-gold orb—and reduced into so much scrap before it faded into the ether.

"Excellent work, my heart," Lyra praised with a proud smile. "The formulae were flawless and your incanting was fast for your skill level while also being clear." Caspin's smile at the praise highlighted their cat features as his tail curled in pleasure. It was always nice to be praised for his hard work.

"Next," Lyra began as she started to make her way over to her enchanting table, "we're going to work on the creation of enchanted items."

"But don't I already do that with my imbuing?" Caspin asked with a tilt of their head as they followed their mother.

"You do," Lyra said with a nod, "but there's a stark difference between the two at this moment in time: your imbuing only lasts a few hours at best whereas I'll now be teaching you how to make the effect permanent." As she was talking, Lyra ran through the books on the floating shelf until she found the one she was looking for and pulled it out.

Book in hand, she turned to face her youngest child and continued, "You are *very* skilled with your innate magic and they'll no doubt allow you to intuitively understand some of this but you'll need to change your method of thinking if you want to progress further."

"What do you mean?" Caspin asked as he took the book from his mother. It was, unsurprisingly, a book on the basics of enchanting.

"What I mean is this: right now, you are filling in the gaps of the object or yourself with magic that confers the property or properties you desire, correct?" At Caspin's nod, she continued. "What you need to do for a proper enchantment is weave the spell into the very essence of the object; you need to make the two inseparable by all but powerful abjuration."

"Or Catra's claws," Caspin remarked dryly as they leafed through the book. Their skimming revealed that a decent chunk of it seemed to be things that he either already knew or was putting words to things that he knew intuitively.

Lyra chuckled. "Yes, or Catra's claws. Now, I want to see how much you can grasp intuitively now that I've pointed out the difference to you before we delve into specifics. You're apparently quite fond of making yours claws as strong as indorium so," she plucked a pen from her desk and handed it to them, "I want you to try and enchant that with those properties. Remember that

you’re not filling in the gaps but are instead intertwining the spell and the pen.”

Caspin regarded the pen for a few moments, idly twirling it before closing their eyes and concentrating. He started to instinctively imbue it like he normally would but they managed to catch themself. It wouldn’t do for them to completely fail their first attempt at properly enchanting.

The instructions were paradoxically simple yet complicated. He already knew that everything in the world was composed of a sort of quintessence—the thing that makes that object or person be that object or person. In people, that something would typically be called the soul but objects were, obviously, different. The quintessence of an object was more like the conceptual idea of it rather than the thing itself.

Caspin had some degree of familiarity with manipulating quintessence—that’s what magic essentially was at its core. However, there was a difference between using spell circles, runic arrays, and incantations to bring about a certain effect within the world and what he was currently trying to do. When it comes to casting a spell, one was simply telling the world “Do this” and then making that thing happen. For enchanting, one was saying “Gain this” and making it not only happen but making it permanent.

As things currently stood, Caspin’s imbuing was somewhere in between the two. He was taking an object or a part of himself and saying “Become like this.” Like their mother had said, they used their magic to fill in the “gaps” of the target’s quintessence with the property that he desired. So long as the magic filling those “gaps” existed, the property would continue

What Caspin figured that he needed to do was combine the two. He needed to weave his spell in such a way that it slotted into those “gaps” and then bind it in place. While it wasn’t quite the “weaving” that their mother had described, this was what

made the most sense to them. So long as the end result was the same, the different process likely didn't matter.

So, that is precisely what he would try to do. Or, rather, that is precisely what they *would* do. Intent was an important part of magic and any ambiguity in intent could lead to either the spell going awry or just simply not happening. Do or do not, there is no try.

A pale blue runic array flared to life around Caspin's hand as they chanted the word of power needed to bring about the desired result. While they didn't need those things to use his innate magic, in this case, he figured that the extra help wouldn't hurt.

(They had the feeling that, one day, they'd be able to do at least basic enchantments with the same ease that he does with his imbuing. That day wasn't today, however.)

In the matter of mere seconds, the spell was complete and the pen was hopefully enchanted. At the very least, he could feel the magic lingering in it and it didn't feel the same as their imbuing.

Lyra took the pen from Caspin and examined it closely, turning it this way and that. "An enchantment is certainly there," she began, "but we'll have to see how strong it is and how long it lasts." She then tossed the pen towards the center of the primary spell circle before casting two spells in rapid succession. The first surrounded the pen in a box of force while the second was a strong explosion centered directly on the pen.

Lyra then retrieved the pen and examined it once more. "The pen itself is completely undamaged so the correct property was bestowed—not that I'm surprised," she said as she walked back over to the desk where she retrieved a piece of paper. She scribbled on it and let out a pleased hum when it still worked. "And it didn't lose its original function. So far, you have once more done an excellent job. Now all we have to do is wait and see how long it lasts."

While they waited, Lyra went over the basics of enchanting in detail while also leading Caspin through several exercises to improve his control and casting time. She tested the duration of the enchantment three more times over the course of the three hours that they worked. The first two had the same results as the original test but the third…

Lyra hummed as she looked at the damaged pen. It was still intact and functional but it was chipped in several places. Caspin was more than a little annoyed by their failure but Lyra reassured them by saying, "While not a complete success, this *did* last significantly longer than your imbuing. You did *much* better than I did on my first attempt at enchanting."

"What happened?" Caspin asked as he tried to push down his disappointment and remain realistic.

Lyra gave her youngest child a sly smile. "Let's just say that my teacher was missing an eyebrow for a while." Caspin couldn't help but laugh at that.

"So, now what?"

"We call it here for the day. I want you to read that book cover-to-cover before our next session where we'll try again."

Caspin nodded resolutely. They were starting to feel mentally and magically drained anyway; sorcery training was a special kind of exhausting.

He knew that he still had a long way to go before he could reach their nebulous goal but they *would* reach it one day for Caspin was nothing if not determined.

The Training Grounds

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Caspin bounced on their toes as his tail lashed behind him, too excited to stay still. The last time they had trained with their dad a bit over a week ago, he had said that it was finally time for him to get a proper martial arts instructor and today was the day that Caspin was *finally* going to meet her.

"Easy there, kiddo. Don't want to tire yourself out before she even gets here," Cyrus said teasingly as he ruffled his youngest's mane.

Caspin grumbled and batted his hand away, earning him a laugh. "I'm just excited!" Caspin borderline whined. "I'm meeting my new teacher *and* one of 'Dora's friends!" He was so excited that he easily ignored the pang in their heart that came from remembering their kidnapped honorary big sis.

Cyrus had noticed over the course of Caspin's training that they preferred more fluid motions, staying mobile and fluid to strike from odd angles. As such, he had determined to find a fighting style that best fit this. It had taken a fair bit of digging but, as it turned out, the fighting style pioneered by cave culture folk was an almost perfect match.

From there, Cyrus had asked Kesi if she knew anyone trained in that style or if she could put out feelers if she didn't. While Kesi hadn't personally known someone, Adora *had* and thus that was how Clover came to be hired as Caspin's personal martial arts instructor.

As if summoned by Caspin's impatience, Clover entered the training grounds.

Clover was short for a Magicat—not as short as Catra but not that much taller, either. Her build was lithe but she carried with her a sense of strength in the way her muscles flexed beneath her

dark grey fur. Her green eyes were kind and friendly yet also sharp as she took in everything and everyone around her without missing a single detail.

Her shoulder-length, white mane was tipped with red and woven into a small braid on her left side. The braid and her bangs framed her angular face.

She was wearing a red chestwrap over which was a royal blue vest. Her billowy pants were a similar shade of blue and appeared to be made from some sort of silken material and were cinched at the ankles. On her arms were a series of armbands, bracelets, and cuffs connected to each other by a series of crisscrossing silvery chains. Similar cuffs but without the chains adorned her tail.

Like basically everyone in cave culture, she had several pieces: three in her left ear and four in her right as well as one on her nave and two above her left eyebrow. Just like Adora, they were all either small hoops or studs—nothing that could easily be grabbed in a fight.

Caspin knew immediately even without seeing her fight that they wanted to be just like her when he got older.

"Hello, Your Majesty, Your Highness," Clover said with a bow.

"Clover," Cyrus greeted with a nod. "No need for formalities here; on the training grounds, all are equal."

Clover smiled. "I figured as much but I didn't want to assume."

"You're so cool," Caspin said almost reverently as they looked at Clover with stars in their eyes.

Clover chuckled. "Thank you! I made sure to put on my finest before I came here."

"So, Clover, care to give a demonstration so that way Caspin here can see what he'll be learning?" Cyrus asked as he nodded

towards a training dummy.

"Of course. I'd be more than glad to."

Clover approached the training dummy and slid into a loose guard stance standing perpendicular to it. She was bouncing slightly on the balls of her feet and slightly shifting her weight from one foot to the other in rhythm that only she could hear. She had her arms raised and her claws extended, her arms also slightly moving with the rhythm.

And then she moved.

Her strikes were as swift as a raging gale almost too fast for Caspin to see and were delivered with the power of a stray bolt of lightning. She almost literally danced around her target as she lashed out with hands, both sets of claws, elbows, knees, and kicks. Her movements were mesmerizing, almost enchanting.

After several eternal seconds—almost half a minute—Clover slid to a stop and drew herself up as she let out a controlled breath.

That was it. That was the fighting style that would be absolutely perfect for Caspin. Already, their mind was racing with ideas for how he could combine his imbuing with the movements that they saw to produce truly devastating results.

"So, what did you think, Caspin?" Clover asked as she turned to face them.

"Please teach me everything you know."

Clover chuckled, a smile on her lips and she thumbed her nose. "Gladly. Fair warning: I'm not the easiest teacher to have."

"I don't care," Caspin reassured her with a shake of their head. "I *need* to be able to fight like you."

Cyrus chuckled this time. “Well, I guess I’ll leave you two to it. Good like, buddy,” he said as he cuffed Caspin on the shoulder before taking his leave.

As Clover started to teach Caspin the basic forms, their path solidified in his mind. The next time trouble came, he wouldn’t be a burden.

End Notes

Fun fact: this started life as a chapter of *Heroes of Halfmoon* until I realized that it's more fitting as a side story due to the way it's structured and what it's about.

I hope you liked what little you've seen of Clover because you'll be seeing more of her in the future. It'll likely be a while before *Heroes of Halfmoon* catches up to that point, though.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!